

Jolted by Trump’s call for takeover of Gaza

President reimagines the area as a ‘Riviera’ without Palestinians. Israel’s Arab neighbors swiftly reject the idea.

By Laura King and Nabih Bulos

TEL AVIV — President Trump’s declaration that the United States wants to “take over” the war-ravaged Gaza Strip and permanently resettle Palestinians living there was met Wednesday with a mixture of scorn and disbelief across the region and beyond — but greeted with delight by right-wing allies of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

Trump’s vague but far-reaching proposals, unveiled during a White House visit by Netanyahu on Tuesday, were swiftly denounced by critics as a call for ethnic cleansing, in violation of international law.

His plan, and Netanyahu’s quick praise of Trump’s “thinking outside the box,” cast a shadow over a tentative truce in Gaza, which last month temporarily halted a devastating 15-month war between Israel and the Palestinian militant group Hamas.

“The U.S. will take over the Gaza Strip, and we will do a job with it, too,” Trump said at a joint news conference in Washington with the Israeli leader by his side.

In some respects, the Gaza proposal was in line with Trump’s embrace of startling territorial ambitions, such as taking control of Greenland, making Canada a 51st state and grabbing back the Panama Canal.

But Gaza — marked by decades of bloodshed — is a [See Gaza, A4]

President orders ban on trans athletes

Move is intended to prevent people who were assigned male at birth from competing with girls and women.

By Will Graves

President Trump signed an executive order on Wednesday designed to ban transgender athletes from participating in women’s or girls’ sporting events.

The order, titled “Keeping Men Out of Women’s Sports,” gives federal agencies, including the Justice and Education departments, wide latitude to ensure entities that receive federal funding abide by Title IX in alignment with the Trump administration’s view, which interprets a person’s sex as the gender they were assigned at birth.

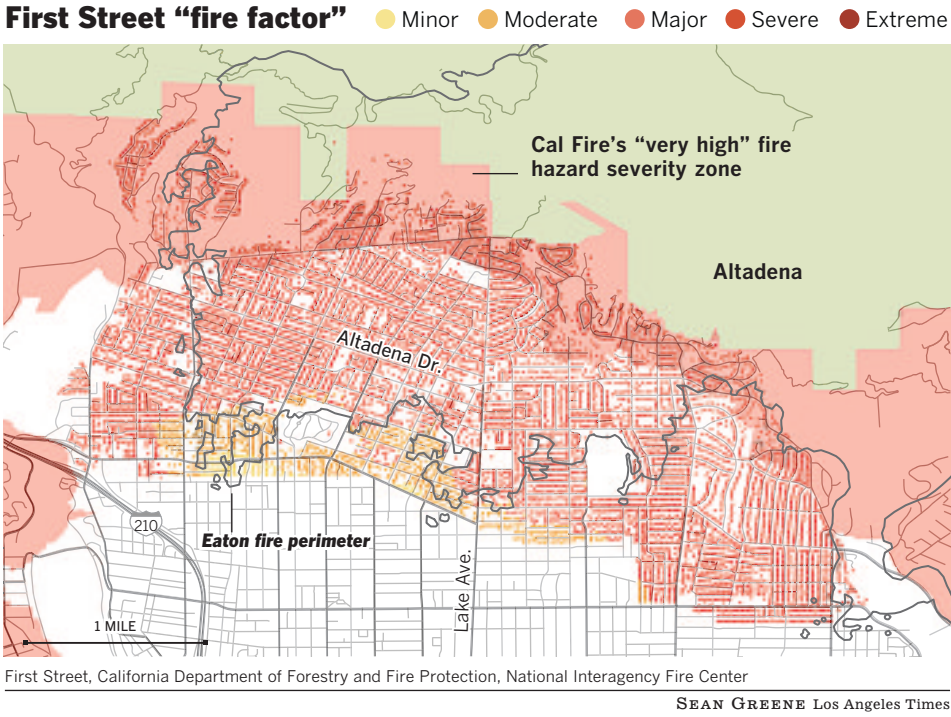
“With this executive order, the war on women’s sports is over,” Trump said at a signing ceremony that included lawmakers and female athletes who have [See Trans ban, A7]



A FIREFIGHTER runs toward a burning home Jan. 7 in Altadena, where persistent high winds pushed the fire far into developed areas.

Cal Fire projection failed Altadena

An independent firm’s disaster maps more accurately foretold the outcome



By Noah Haggerty, Ben Poston and Sean Greene

The Tunnel fire broke out in a wooded canyon just minutes away from UC Berkeley, where David Sapsis was working on his PhD in fire science. Five years into a drought, on a torrid October morning in 1991, with the wind whipping at over 60 mph, Sapsis knew it spelled trouble.

An eyewitness watched as a single ember landed on a tree just outside the burn area, igniting it. Then, all hell broke loose. The fire would go on to kill 25 people and injure 150 more. It engulfed more than 3,800 structures throughout the hilly communities and raced toward Oakland.

But then, the winds died down. Sapsis — who would

spend much of the aftermath studying the forensics of the fire — was left with a terrifying thought that has stuck with him ever since.

“That fire,” he said, “could have gone to Lake Merritt if the winds would have persisted.” Straight through Oakland.

Thirty-three years later, Sapsis, who now leads Cal Fire’s hazard mapping efforts, watched his nightmare play out in real time in Altadena. With exceptional winds that blew the fire deep into an urban center, and exceptional dryness that provided the fuel for the flames to keep growing, it was a scenario Cal Fire knew its fire models couldn’t handle.

“I do believe, when we start to complete some research synopsis of this fire event,” Sapsis said, “that we’re going to be looking at a [See Maps, A9]

China, in its quest for economic dominance, turns to Latin America

Trump’s unpredictable presidency presents opportunity to Beijing in its push to end U.S. hegemony in region.

By Kate Linticum and Stephanie Yang

During a nine-day trip through Latin America in the fall, Chinese President Xi Jinping met with the leaders of Mexico, Brazil, Bolivia, Chile and Argentina and inaugurated a \$3-billion Chinese-funded port in Peru.

Over and over, Xi stressed his interest in strengthening economic ties with the region 10,000 miles from Beijing.

“True friends always feel close to each other,” he told China’s official news agency.

“No matter the distance between them.”

Over the last two decades, China has begun to challenge longtime U.S. hegemony in Latin America. In at least six countries — Panama, Peru, Chile, Uruguay, Brazil and Bolivia — it has surged ahead of the United States as the biggest trading partner.

Now experts say China has been handed another opportunity in its quest to dominate the region: the presidency of Donald Trump.

In his first two weeks in office, Trump has strong-armed American allies, using the threat of tariffs to extract concessions from Colombia and then Mexico. At the same time, he has halted — and threatened to eliminate — many U.S. foreign assistance programs that have [See Dominance, A4]

‘Pineapple Express’ lands in L.A.

By Rong-Gong Lin II, Hannah Fry and Nathan Solis

The first of two “Pineapple Express” storms arrived in Southern California early Wednesday after delivering a stronger-than-expected pounding to Northern California, breaking rainfall records, swelling rivers and triggering landslides.

In the Sonoma County town of Forestville, a house fell into the Russian River after a rain-saturated hillside gave way. All low-lying areas of the river downstream of Healdsburg — including Guerneville — remain under evacuation orders through Thursday morning because of flooding risk, according to Sonoma County.

The storm weakened significantly as it moved down the state, but another atmospheric river — of similar strength — is expected to hit the Southland on Thursday. Forecasters are predicting [See Storm, A7]

First of this week’s two storms causes few issues locally, but a third next week could be wetter



FOLLOWING heavy rain in Marin County, men push a vehicle stuck on a flooded road near Muir Beach.

Deadly bird flu in Nevada cattle

A version of H5N1 that killed a person in Louisiana is detected in dairy herds. **NATION, A6**

Fears as Trump targets education

Financial aid, student loans and other federal programs could be affected. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Closure of a tariff loophole

U.S. move involving lower-cost items could change online fashion shopping. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

A little rain. L.A. Basin: 64/55. **B6**

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